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The Fast Lane to Ugliness

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The Fast Lane to Ugliness

Charm is deceptive and beauty is fleeting, but a woman who fears the Lord is to be praised. (Proverbs 31:30)

False are charms and vain is the beauty of woman; for a prudent woman is blessed. Let her praise the fear of the Lord. (Proverbs 31:30, Septuagint)

Ah, Hollywood and the media biz. Is it not the world's "Beauty Obsession Center"? Cosmetic surgery. Endless makeovers. Outrageously priced clothing and hair care. Rodeo Drive and Fifth Avenue with "personal shoppers" who seduce the gullible with promises of everlasting attractiveness. It's where "You're looking beautiful" is said before "Hello."

As a person who's lived many decades, I discover that almost nobody refers to me as "handsome" or even "good-looking" anymore. The inevitable toll of the years whittles away at any natural, physical comeliness God may have given us. All the cosmetic efforts in the universe can't stop the whittling. Let's face it—physical ugliness is inevitable. Not many beautiful faces in nursing homes!

Proverbs calls physical attractiveness "fleeting." A sudden disfiguring accident or disease or stroke and all the effort invested in enhancing one's physical beauty can be turned into ugliness—in a nanosecond.

Principle: Obsession with personal appearance is an exercise in futility. Its benefits are short-lived and can be stolen in an instant.

God places emphasis on *inner* beauty. "Man looks at the outward appearance, but the Lord looks on the heart," says 1 Samuel 16:7. Show me a person with external comeliness and a bitter angry spirit, and I will show you a person on the fast lane to ugliness...externally as well as internally. Show me a person with a righteous, joyful, tranquil, gracious, loving spirit; and I will show you a person whose "attractiveness of spirit" will make you forget their lack of physical attractiveness.

Principle: The beauty of a person's character is the ultimate "cosmetic surgery" that creates loveliness through the ultimate "faith lift."

The word *cosmetics* is rooted in the Greek word *cosmos*; one meaning of which is “arrangement.” When cosmetics are applied, they are designed to alter the “arrangement” of the face or body—a purely surface alteration. When the face is reflecting the beauty of the inner spirit, its attractiveness is rooted deep within... where aging cannot reach.

Principle: To improve your appearance dramatically, get a “spiritual makeover.”

A spiritual makeover may cost you dearly, but it won’t be in dollars. It’ll be in confessed...and forgiven...sins.

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]